

DecisionBrief — Conversation Transcript

Scenario: business-software • Small Business + SCM System + Inventory Tracking + \$5k Budget

2026-05-14 02:05 PM

DecisionBrief: Thinking about business software? Tell me about your business and what problem you're trying to solve?

You: I own a small eco home goods business in Austin — 18 employees, 2 warehouses, about 120 SKUs. We do about 80 orders a day normally, 200 a day peak. I manage 12 suppliers across Mexico and US. Currently we run on QuickBooks Online + Google Sheets + Shopify + email with suppliers. Inventory is manual and orders slip.

2026-05-14 02:06 PM

DecisionBrief: Got it — 18-person eco goods, 2 warehouses, 120 SKUs, QuickBooks + Sheets + Shopify today. What triggered the need to replace it now?

You: We stocked out of our top 5 sellers 3 times last quarter and overbought slow movers — \$30k tied up in dead stock. Spreadsheets broke with 2 warehouses, we can't see real stock. Q4 holiday rush starts early October and we need a system live before September. Manual cycle counts every week are killing the team.

2026-05-14 02:07 PM

DecisionBrief: Understood — 3 stockouts, \$30k dead stock, Sheets failing across warehouses, Q4 deadline September. What have you considered so far?

You: We looked at Cin7, Zoho Inventory, Fishbowl, and Katana. Tested Zoho — cheap but procurement tools weak, no supplier lead time. Cin7 we liked but quoted \$9k/year over our budget. Katana good for manufacturing but inventory tracking is light. Friend said stick with Sheets + hire inventory person but I hate manual work.

2026-05-14 02:08 PM

DecisionBrief: Clear — Zoho procurement weak, Cin7 \$9k over budget, Katana light on inventory, hire-person idea you dislike. What's your budget and timeline?

You: Budget \$5k hard cap \$8k if perfect annually including tax/fees. Can do \$3k one-time for migration help. Currently paying \$400/month for QuickBooks + Shopify apps + ShipStation combined. Need to stay under \$700/month total including new software and apps. Need 6 users — me, ops manager, 2 warehouse leads, 2 packing staff. Must be live by September 1.

2026-05-14 02:09 PM

DecisionBrief: Got it — \$5k cap \$8k perfect, \$3k migration, \$400/mo current to under \$700/mo total, 6 users, live by Sept 1. What must it actually do?

You: Needs real-time inventory across 2 warehouses with low-stock alerts, barcode scanning for receiving and picking so team can use phones, order management automating Shopify orders to warehouse to ShipStation without Sheets, procurement tools for 12 suppliers with PO tracking and lead times, cloud dashboard I can check from phone, and integrations with Shopify and QuickBooks Online and ShipStation. Easy for non-technical warehouse staff — if it's complex they won't use it.

2026-05-14 02:10 PM

DecisionBrief: Understood — real-time across 2 warehouses, barcode, auto order flow Shopify to ShipStation, POs for 12 suppliers, cloud mobile dashboard, Shopify/QBO/ShipStation integrations, simple for staff. What worries you most about this decision?

You: Buying Zoho and finding procurement fails during Q4 and we stock out anyway. Buying Cin7 at \$9k and still needing custom work to connect QuickBooks. Migrating from Sheets and losing order history or getting inventory

wrong and shutting down shipping for days. Suppliers ignoring portal and we go back to email. And buying something that can't scale if we add a 3rd warehouse next year.

2026-05-14 02:12 PM

DecisionBrief: Thanks — procurement failure risk, \$9k overage risk, migration downtime risk, supplier adoption, and 3rd warehouse scale are kev. What does success look like in 12 months?

You: No stockouts on top 20 SKUs for 12 months, inventory accuracy 98%+ without weekly manual counts, orders processed same-day without me checking Sheets, POs automated to 12 suppliers with lead time tracking, cloud dashboard showing live stock from phone, stayed under \$5k/year plus \$3k migration, warehouse team scanning barcodes daily without complaints, and handled Q4 rush of 200 orders a day without extra hires. And QuickBooks stays in sync.

2026-05-14 02:13 PM

DecisionBrief: I have enough information to prepare your Decision Brief.